

## SELF-LOADING PISTOLS (1893–1900)

The final decade of the 19th century saw an extraordinary upsurge in the development of reliable self-loading, or “semiautomatic,” pistols, which could fire one round with every pull of the trigger. They worked on recoil operation (see p.305)—by using a spring to harness the power in the recoil of the fired cartridge to reload the weapon. It was Hiram Maxim who had perfected recoil action in machine-guns (see pp.184–85), following which gunmakers began applying it to other weapons.



### ▲ BORCHARDT C.93

Date 1894

Origin Germany

Barrel 6½in (16.5cm)

Caliber 7.65mm

The C.93, developed by gunmaker Hugo Borchardt, was the first successful self-loading pistol. For its loading action, the C.93 drew on the design of Maxim's machine-guns, which Borchardt's employer, Ludwig Loewe, was producing under license in Berlin.

FULL VIEW

### ▲ “MARS,” BY GABBETT-FAIRFAX

Date 1899–1902

Origin UK

Barrel 10½in (26.5cm)

Caliber 8.5mm Mars/.45in Webley

The “Mars” pistol was too big, expensive, complex—and too unforgiving—to succeed in the already congested and competitive weapons market of 1900.

### ▲ MAUSER C.96

Date 1896

Origin Germany

Barrel 5½in (14cm)

Caliber 7.63mm Mauser

Although complicated and slow to load due to its fixed magazine, the “Broom handle” Mauser *Selbstladepestole* (self-loading pistol) soon became popular in military circles thanks to its very powerful ammunition. It remained in production until 1937 and was copied the world over. It was usually supplied with a holster-cum-shoulder stock (like that of the C.93, above), which was essential for safely firing the gun. Fully automatic versions, which could fire continuously while the trigger was pulled, were also produced.